

MUGHAL ARMOUR AND WEAPONS

The **Mughal Empire** had its beginnings in 1526, when steppe nomads from Central Asia swept into India from the northwest, occupying much of the subcontinent by the late 17th century. They were heavily influenced by Persia, and brought with them similar weapons, including guns. The Mughal army was divided into cavalry, infantry, and artillery. In similar style to the Mamluks, the heavy cavalry wore mail and plate armour and rode armoured horses, fighting with bow, lance, and sword. Armoured elephants saw limited use as they were unreliable and difficult to control. The infantry fought chiefly with guns and swords, but lacked a coordinated command structure, which limited their effectiveness.

▼ ELEPHANT ARMOUR

Date c.1600

Origin India

Material Ferrous metal, copper alloy, leather

Panels of mail and plate were used for elephant armour. These were inset with plaques that were decorated with flowers, fish, and running elephants. A pair of swords could be sheathed above the tusks.

Mahout controlling elephant

Fighting man

Mail and plate head section



Scalloped plates protect the skull

▲ TOP

Date 17th century

Origin India

Material Ferrous metal, textile (lining fragment)

Made of horizontal bands of vertically arranged plates joined by mail, this helmet originally had a heavily padded lining. The triangular section of mail hung in front of the face.

► ZEREH BAGTAR

Date Early 17th century

Origin India

Material Ferrous metal, copper alloy, leather, red silk, gold threads

A Mughal horse-warrior wore a plated cuirass combined with a coat of mail that reached his knees. It was often zinc-plated to prevent rusting and damage to the padded garment worn underneath. Although it did not offer the level of protection of an all-over plate armour, it was relatively light and flexible.

Heaviest links over chest

